show, for example, that people understood the medicinal properties of many plants. In the text *History of Animals*, written in the 4th century BCE, the Greek philosopher and scholar Aristotle made the first serious attempt to classify organisms, studying their anatomy, life cycles, and behavior.

“If any person thinks the examination of the rest of the animal kingdom an unworthy task, he must hold in like disesteem the study of man.”

Aristotle

Features of classification

Aristotle divided living things into plants and animals. He further grouped about 500 species of animals according to obvious anatomical features, such as whether they had blood, were “warm-blooded” or “cold-blooded,” whether they had four legs or more, and whether they gave birth to live offspring or laid eggs. He also noted whether animals lived in the sea, on land, or flew in the air. Most significantly, Aristotle used names for his groupings that were later translated into the Latin words “genus” and “species”—terms that are still used by modern taxonomists to this day.

Aristotle placed animals in a *scala naturae* (ladder of nature), with 11 grades distinguished by their mode of birth. Those in the top grades gave birth to live, hot, wet offspring; those in the lower grades to cold, dry eggs. Humans were at the very top of the scale, with live-bearing tetrapods (four-legged creatures), cetaceans, birds, and egg-laying tetrapods lower down. Aristotle placed minerals on the bottom grade of his scale, with plants, worms, sponges, larva-bearing insects, and hard-shelled animals on the levels above.

While Aristotle’s system of classification was rudimentary, it was based largely on first-hand observations, many of which were made on the island of Lesvos. He recorded things that no one else had described, including that young dogfish grew inside their mothers’ bodies, male river catfish guard